the armed forces of the Soviet Union. This ran contrary to Mao's doctrine of an ideologically motivated 'people's army' that would be indoctrinated by studying the writings of the Great Chairman. Mao's vision of a good soldier was to be embodied in Lei Feng, the fictitious character created later; the loyal fighter who wanted to be 'a stainless-steel screw for the Party'.[61]

The ideological aspect of the 1962 War and that it was part and parcel of power struggles within the CCP at the time have been highlighted by MacFarquhar in his study of China in the 1950s and 1960s, 'The question that remains unanswerable is: if Mao had still been in retirement, would Liu Shaoqi and Zhou Enlai have chosen to teach Mr Nehru a lesson in quite so brutal a fashion? Probably not, in the light of their support for *san he yi shao*.'[62]

'San he yi shao' was a notion advanced by Wang Jiaxiang, an erstwhile comrade-in-arms of Mao and a former Chinese ambassador to the Soviet Union. It can be translated as 'three peaceful acts and one reduction' and referred to his proposed conciliation with the imperialists (the United States), the revisionists (the Soviet Union), and the reactionaries (India), while reducing aid to the world's revolutionary forces.[63]

According to Sergey Radchenko, a specialist on Sino-Soviet relations, Mao was fiercely opposed to this idea.

> Mao talked about national security and national pride. He wanted the world to know that China could not be intimidated, and that Beijing's stern warnings to India were not a bluff. He knew that the People's Liberation Army was in a position to inflict a shattering blow to the Indian Army and so assert China's claim to regional hegemony. National security concerns and illusions of grandeur were very good reasons for a war with India.[64]

India had been identified by everyone in the top leadership of the CCP as the main regional enemy as early as 1959, and could therefore serve as a unifying factor as well as a pretext for purging the Party of 'revisionists' and other 'undesirable elements'. At the time India was facing a highly disciplined and brilliantly efficient war machine in the Himalayas, it was not known that China was barely recovering from one of the worst famines in its history, a manmade disaster created by Mao's own disastrous policies.

Following the Communist takeover of China in 1949, big and small landlords had their land confiscated and distributed among poorer peasants. Collectivization of land had to wait because there would have been